Low-stakes quizzes

Making retrieval accessible and challenging

Use a recurring low-stakes quiz to revisit knowledge across topics and identify what each student needs to retrieve again. The review matters as much as the score.

How to do it well

1 Plan the content. Select curriculum-critical material across recent and older topics, including short procedures and conceptual distinctions.

2 Establish the routine. Keep timing, response location and expectations predictable; students attempt without copying or consulting solutions.

3 Commit before review. Where useful, ask students to rate confidence in each answer before they discover whether it is correct.

4 Review selectively. Show accurate worked solutions and spend most explanation time on high-value gaps and confidently held errors.

5 Create future practice. Students make Review Cards or equivalent retrieval prompts, then revisit them in later quizzes, Do Nows or homework.

What this sounds like

“Answer independently. Before we review, rate your confidence. We will begin with important errors and turn those into questions you can practise again.”

Classroom example. A weekly Maths quiz includes recently practised work and older content. Pupils answer alone and rate confidence before review. The teacher shows worked solutions and spends most time on an important confidently held error. Pupils turn that item into a Review Card and encounter related questions again in later quizzes and homework.

Top tips that make the technique work

Mix recent and older material. Use a deliberate retrieval plan rather than a quiz on whichever questions are easiest to find.

Record confidence before feedback. Confidently held errors can guide the order of review and Review Card creation.

Reveal complete solutions. Students need to see the important decision or method, not merely the final answer.

Keep scores in perspective. The quiz is a learning opportunity; avoid public comparison or turning every attempt into a high-stakes assessment.

Convert errors into retrieval. A corrected script is harder to self-quiz from than a question on the front of a Review Card.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Protect the independent attempt and feedback sequence.	Only testing this week’s content.
Plan a later return to corrected knowledge.	Giving a score without explaining the relevant errors.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton - Low-Stakes Quiz | DistillED - Retrieval Practice